More women owners, or more women working at home on contract? Women's enterprise ownership in India, 2015–16 to 2023–24

Preet Deep Singh*

Abstract. The share of India's unincorporated non-agricultural enterprises owned by women rose sharply in the last decade, a change often read as growing women's entrepreneurship. Using the unit-level data of the NSS 73rd round (2015–16) and the Annual Survey of Unincorporated Sector Enterprises 2023–24, we ask where the new women-owned enterprises are. We decompose the change in the number of female-proprietor enterprises into cells defined by activity, location (inside or outside the owner's home), dependence on a contractor and rural or urban area, and split the change in the female share into a within-cell and a between-cell part. We then compare the returns of these enterprises, measured as gross value added per worker, with the earnings women could expect outside them, estimated from the Periodic Labour Force Survey 2023–24. The female-proprietor share in the harmonised coverage rose from 19.5 to 26.3 per cent, driven by changes within cells. Home-based enterprises account for 56.9 per cent of the rise in the number of women owners, but contract work does not: the share of female-proprietor enterprises working mainly for a contractor fell from 31.2 to 17.0 per cent. Returns remain low. The median female-proprietor enterprise generates Rs 3,558 of value added per worker per month, and 80.1 per cent generate less than 25 days of the casual wage. The new women-owned enterprises are more independent than the old, but

*Independent Researcher, New Delhi, India. ORCID: 0000-0003-3721-7548.

most are small home-based units that pay less than wage work; ownership counts should be read alongside location and returns.

Keywords: women's entrepreneurship; home-based work; putting-out; informal enterprises; India

JEL codes: J16, L26, O17, J22

Plain English Summary. More of India's small non-farm businesses are now owned by women. We use two large government surveys, from 2015–16 and 2023–24, to see what kind of businesses these are. Most of the growth is in very small businesses run from home. Fewer of them now work for a contractor who supplies the work and buys the output, so in that sense they have become more independent. But most of them still earn less per worker than a woman could earn as a daily wage labourer. The number of women business owners is a weak guide to women's economic progress. Policy that counts women owners should also track where they work, who they work for, and what they earn.

1 Introduction

India's official enterprise surveys show a fast rise in women's ownership of unincorporated non-agricultural enterprises. In the NSS 73rd round (2015–16), 19.5 per cent of enterprises in our harmonised coverage were owned by a woman proprietor; in the Annual Survey of Unincorporated Sector Enterprises (ASUSE) 2023–24 the figure was 26.3 per cent (National Sample Survey Office, 2016; National Statistics Office, 2025). The published factsheet for 2023–24 reports a rise from 22.9 per cent in 2022–23 to 26.2 per cent in a single year (National Statistics Office, 2025). Because these surveys are the main source on India's informal enterprises, the rise is widely cited as evidence of growing women's entrepreneurship.

This paper asks a simple question: where are the new women-owned enterprises, and what do they earn? Ownership in these surveys is a statement about who runs the enterprise; it says nothing about whether the enterprise sells on its own account, is run from a separate workplace, or earns more than the owner's alternatives. A woman who stitches garments at home for a contractor who supplies the cloth and buys every piece is recorded as the

proprietor of an own-account manufacturing enterprise. So is a woman who runs a shop. The two are different economic situations, and the literature on home-based and subcontracted work has long argued that the first is closer to dependent wage work than to entrepreneurship (Kabeer, Mahmud, and Tasneem, 2018; Kesar, 2024).

We make three contributions. First, we bring the two surveys onto a common coverage and decompose the change in the number of female-proprietor enterprises into cells defined by broad activity, location of the enterprise (in the owner's home or outside), dependence on a contractor (work done solely or mainly on contract) and rural or urban area. A shift-share split separates growth of women's ownership within cells from reallocation of enterprises across cells. Second, we profile the growth margin, the enterprises that account for most of the rise. Third, we benchmark the returns of these enterprises against the outside option of the women who run them, the earnings of women casual workers and self-employed women in the Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS) 2023–24 (National Statistics Office, 2024). This benchmark turns a statement about ownership into a statement about welfare: an enterprise that generates less value added per worker than the casual wage is a poor route out of low-paid work, whatever its legal form.

The closest studies are Bose (2023), who documents a large productivity penalty for women-owned home-based manufacturing firms in the 2015–16 data, Kesar (2024), who shows that women-owned informal enterprises are far more likely to work under subcontract, and Mohanan and Kar (2025), who link the recent growth of unorganised manufacturing to women's job work. Shuvam and Mohanty (2023) classify proprietorship by necessity and opportunity motives across earlier rounds. None of these studies follows the change from 2015–16 to the post-pandemic ASUSE rounds across manufacturing, trade and services, decomposes it by home location and contract dependence together, or compares enterprise returns with women's outside option. The paper also speaks to work on gender gaps in microenterprise returns (de Mel, McKenzie, and Woodruff, 2009; Fafchamps et al., 2014), on credit and ownership in India (Chaudhuri, Sasidharan, and Raj, 2020), on the local determinants of female entrepreneurship (Ghani, Kerr, and O'Connell, 2013) and on the stagnation and measurement of women's work in India (Deshpande and Kabeer, 2021; Klasen and Pieters,

2015).

The answer to the question in the title is mixed. The rise in women's ownership is not a rise in putting-out: of the 6.7 point increase in the female share, 9.2 points occurred within cells, while the shrinking weight of home-based contract manufacturing, where women's ownership was already high, pulled the share down by 2.5 points. The number of female-proprietor enterprises working mainly for a contractor fell from 38.6 lakh to 32.5 lakh. But the growth is concentrated in home-based enterprises selling on their own account, which account for 65.3 per cent of the rise, and these generate far less value added per worker than men's enterprises or than casual wage work.

2 Data

2.1 Enterprise surveys

The NSS 73rd round (July 2015 to June 2016, Schedule 2.34) and ASUSE 2023–24 (October 2023 to September 2024) are nationally representative surveys of unincorporated non-agricultural enterprises, excluding construction, run by the National Statistics Office with a two-stage stratified design (National Sample Survey Office, 2016; National Statistics Office, 2025). ASUSE succeeded the earlier rounds with a near-identical schedule, so the items we use are asked in nearly the same form in both (we map the codes item by item; see the code repository): type of ownership (with separate codes for male, female and transgender proprietors), location of the enterprise (within household premises or outside), whether the enterprise is an own-account enterprise (no regular hired worker) or an establishment, whether it works on contract and, if so, whether solely or mainly for a contractor or mainly for its own customers, whether the contractor supplies raw material or equipment, months of operation, usual hours a day, and the number of working owners, hired workers and unpaid helpers by sex. The released NSS 73rd round file holds 290,113 enterprise records and the ASUSE 2023–24 file 523,775 establishment records (the latter including residential renting); after harmonising coverage we keep 289,843 and 495,451 records.

We use the final multipliers supplied with each data set, the average of the two semi-round multipliers for the 2015–16 round as prescribed in its estimation procedure, and the stratum and first-stage unit identifiers for the design-based standard errors. To compare like with like we restrict both rounds to manufacturing (NIC 2008 divisions 10–33), trade (45–47) and other services (49–96 except 84), and drop residential renting (NIC 68108), which ASUSE tabulates separately. "Female-proprietor enterprise" means proprietary ownership by a woman; partnerships, self-help groups, cooperatives and other forms are kept as a third category.

2.2 Returns and the outside option

Gross value added (GVA) is the survey's own item, computed from receipts and operating expenses for the reference period and annualised following the published procedure (by twelve for perennial enterprises and by the reported months of operation for seasonal and casual ones). We work with monthly GVA per worker, where workers include working owners and unpaid helpers, and restrict the returns analysis to market enterprises. GVA per worker is an upper bound on the owner's earning per worker, because it is before rent, interest and the cost of capital.

The outside option comes from the PLFS 2023–24 unit data. We take the average daily earnings of women in casual wage work in current weekly status (Rs 291 in rural areas and Rs 359 in urban areas; Rs 298 overall, against Rs 450 for men), and the average gross earnings over the last 30 days of self-employed women (Rs 5,497, against Rs 16,150 for men). A month of casual work at 25 days is therefore worth Rs 7,438; we report 22 and 30 days as sensitivity bounds.

2.3 Validation

Before any analysis, each estimate that has a published counterpart is reproduced from the unit data. The PLFS benchmark reproduces the published quarterly all-India average wage of women casual workers in current weekly status within Rs 1.8 a day in rural areas and

within Rs 7.5 in urban areas in every quarter (Rs 2.1 for India as a whole), the male all-India wage within Rs 0.7, and the published 30-day earnings of self-employed women within 0.6 per cent (Table 5 in the Appendix). For the enterprise surveys we reproduce the number of enterprises, the female-proprietor share, GVA per worker and GVA per enterprise for each round (Table 6 in the Appendix): 13 published statistics in all, including the number of workers and total GVA. The largest gap is 0.45 per cent, and every gap is within the rounding of the published figure. Two definitional points matter. First, the published female-owned share for 2023–24 is reproduced only when female proprietary establishments are divided by all establishments (26.17 per cent); as a share of proprietary establishments alone the figure is 27.64 per cent (19.54 and 20.36 per cent in 2015–16). We use the published definition throughout. Second, GVA in both rounds is reproduced only for market enterprises, that is excluding non-profit institutions and head offices (NIC 70100), with the reference-period value annualised as described above.

3 Method

Let c index cells formed by activity (manufacturing, trade, other services), location (home, outside), contract dependence (solely or mainly on contract, otherwise) and area (rural, urban), N_{ct} the weighted number of enterprises in cell c in year t, F_{ct} the number with a female proprietor, $e_{ct} = N_{ct}/\sum_c N_{ct}$ the cell share and $s_{ct} = F_{ct}/N_{ct}$ the female share.

The *count decomposition* reports $\Delta F_c/\sum_c \Delta F_c$, the share of the rise in women owners that each cell accounts for. The *shift-share decomposition* of the change in the overall female share $S_t = \sum_c e_{ct} s_{ct}$ is

$$\Delta S = \sum_c \bar{e}_c \, \Delta s_c + \sum_c \bar{s}_c \, \Delta e_c,$$

with bars denoting the average of the two years; the first term is the within-cell change and the second the change due to growth of cells where women's ownership is high. If the rise were driven by women entering independent enterprise across the board, the within term would dominate in outside, own-market cells; if it were driven by the growth of home-based contract work, the between term and the home and contract cells would dominate.

For returns, we report the weighted median and quartiles of monthly GVA per worker by ownership type, home location and contract dependence, the share of enterprises whose GVA per worker falls below 22, 25 and 30 days of the woman casual wage, and GVA per worker-hour. We then estimate, with survey weights and design-based standard errors, regressions of log GVA per worker on a female-proprietor indicator, urban location, NIC two-digit and state fixed effects (model 1), adding home location, contract dependence, own-account status, log hours a day and log months a year (model 2), and interactions of the female indicator with home and contract (model 3). The change in the female coefficient from model 1 to model 2 measures how much of the raw gap is accounted for by where and how women's enterprises operate, in the spirit of Oaxaca (1973). These regressions describe; they do not identify the effect of ownership on returns.

4 Results

4.1 Where the rise came from

Table 1: Cells accounting for the change in the number of female-proprietor enterprises, 2015–16 to 2023–24 (ten largest)

Cell	2015–16 (lakh)	2023–24 (lakh)	Change (lakh)	Share of change (%)
Manufacturing | home | own-market | rural	25.8	50.2	24.4	35.8
Other services | outside | own-market | urban	3.9	18.8	14.9	21.9
Manufacturing | home | own-market | urban	20.7	28.5	7.7	11.4
Other services | home | own-market | rural	2.9	7.9	5.0	7.3
Trade | outside | own-market | rural	3.8	8.0	4.2	6.1

Cell	2015–16 (lakh)	2023–24 (lakh)	Change (lakh)	Share of change (%)
Other services | outside | own-market | rural	1.4	5.3	4.0	5.8
Other services | home | own-market | urban	7.1	11.0	4.0	5.8
Trade | outside | own-market | urban	5.8	9.4	3.6	5.3
Trade | home | own-market | rural	5.8	8.9	3.1	4.6
Manufacturing | outside | own-market | rural	1.4	3.4	2.0	3.0

The number of female-proprietor enterprises in the harmonised coverage rose from 123.8 lakh to 191.9 lakh. The largest single cell is Manufacturing | home | own-market | rural, which accounts for 35.8 per cent of the rise. Taken together, home-based cells account for 56.9 per cent and contract cells for -8.9 per cent: home-based cells selling on their own account contribute 65.3 per cent, offset in part by the fall in home-based contract manufacturing. In the shift-share split, the female share rose by 6.7 percentage points, of which 9.2 points is within cells and -2.5 points is due to the changing mix of cells.

4.2 The growth margin

Table 2: Profile of proprietary enterprises by sex of owner. Lakh: number of enterprises; OAE, Home, Contract (any work on contract), Mainly contract (solely or mainly for a contractor) and Mfg (manufacturing) are percentages of enterprises; Workers: average per enterprise.

Year	Owner	Lakh	OAE	Home	Contract	Mainly contract	Mfg	Hours/day	Workers
2023-24	Female	191.9	96.7	74.8	17.4	17.0	61.3	5.8	1.24

Year	Owner	Lakh	OAE	Home	Contract	Mainly contract	Mfg	Hours/day	Workers
2023-24	Male	500.1	83.0	23.4	2.6	2.2	16.5	8.4	1.77
2015-16	Female	123.8	96.1	84.7	32.3	31.2	71.5	6.1	1.31
2015-16	Male	484.0	81.4	33.3	4.7	3.9	21.6	8.5	1.80

In 2023–24, 74.8 per cent of female-proprietor enterprises operated from the owner's home, against 23.4 per cent of male-proprietor enterprises, and 17.0 per cent worked solely or mainly on contract, against 2.2 per cent. The share of female-proprietor enterprises working mainly on contract fell from 31.2 per cent in 2015–16, and the share at home from 84.7 per cent. Women's enterprises also became more connected: 14.1 per cent used the internet in 2023–24, against 1.2 per cent in 2015–16. Among female own-account enterprises at home, the share mainly on contract changed from 36.4 to 22.5 per cent, and the share in manufacturing from 80.8 to 77.4 per cent.

4.3 Returns against the outside option

Table 3: Monthly GVA per worker (Rs), market enterprises, 2023–24

Owner	OAE	Home	Contract	Median	P25	P75	< 25 casual days (%)	GVA per hour
Female	Yes	No	No	6,221	3,755	10,020	59.5	41.1
Female	Yes	No	Yes	3,305	1,447	4,810	92.6	27.9
Female	Yes	Yes	No	3,290	1,830	5,541	86.2	31.4
Female	Yes	Yes	Yes	2,230	1,318	3,180	98.7	17.8
Female	No	No	No	14,039	9,781	20,040	13.2	69.8
Female	No	No	Yes	12,991	9,399	17,700	6.5	58.3

Owner	OAE	Home	Contract	Median	P25	P75	< 25 casual days (%)	GVA per hour
Female	No	Yes	No	9,085	6,268	13,382	35.6	55.1
Female	No	Yes	Yes	8,266	6,808	8,266	31.5	27.6
Male	Yes	No	No	11,003	7,219	16,050	26.4	55.6
Male	Yes	No	Yes	9,740	6,440	14,150	36.0	46.1
Male	Yes	Yes	No	6,635	3,800	11,015	55.3	41.8
Male	Yes	Yes	Yes	4,928	2,625	8,285	69.7	25.2
Male	No	No	No	15,045	10,810	20,508	8.6	71.1
Male	No	No	Yes	13,625	10,468	17,665	6.0	59.0
Male	No	Yes	No	11,600	8,026	16,178	20.3	59.6
Male	No	Yes	Yes	10,692	7,912	13,950	21.4	46.7

The median female-proprietor enterprise generates Rs 3,558 of value added per worker per month, against Rs 10,670 for male proprietors and Rs 7,438 for 25 days of women's casual work. 80.1 per cent of female-proprietor enterprises fall below that benchmark, against 30.1 per cent of male-proprietor enterprises. The gap is widest at home: among own-account enterprises that do not work mainly for a contractor, 86.2 per cent of women's home-based units fall below the benchmark, against 59.5 per cent of those outside the home, and women's home-based contract units have a median of only Rs 2,230. Part of the gap is time: female proprietors report 5.8 hours a day against 8.4 for men, and per worker-hour the home-based own-account gap is smaller (Rs 31.4 against Rs 41.8).

In the regressions (Table 4), GVA per worker in female-proprietor enterprises is 52.3 per cent lower than in male-proprietor enterprises in the same activity, state and area. Controlling for home location, contract dependence, own-account status, hours and months, the gap is 35.2 per cent. Working at home is associated with 23.7 per cent lower GVA per worker and contract dependence with 20.9 per cent lower. In model 3 both penalties are larger for women (interaction coefficients -0.117 and -0.127), and the female coefficient for an enterprise outside the home and not on contract is -0.361 log points.

Table 4: Log monthly GVA per worker, proprietary market enterprises, 2023–24 (N = 463,431). Survey-weighted; standard errors in parentheses account for strata and first-stage units. All models include NIC two-digit and state fixed effects.

Variable	(1)	(2)	(3)
Female proprietor	-0.741 (0.015)	-0.433 (0.013)	-0.361 (0.020)
Urban	0.331 (0.010)	0.236 (0.009)	0.234 (0.009)
At home		-0.270 (0.011)	-0.242 (0.011)
Mainly on contract		-0.235 (0.032)	-0.156 (0.049)
Own-account		-0.235 (0.008)	-0.237 (0.008)
Log hours a day		0.622 (0.012)	0.614 (0.012)
Log months a year		0.256 (0.027)	0.256 (0.027)
Female x home			-0.117 (0.022)
Female x contract			-0.127 (0.049)

5 Discussion

The results reject the simplest pessimistic reading of the rise in women's ownership. Had the rise come from the spread of putting-out, with women recorded as proprietors of home-based units that stitch, roll or assemble for a contractor, the contract cells and the between-cell term would carry it. They do not. Contract cells account for -8.9 per cent of the change in the number of women owners, and the between-cell term is negative, because home-based contract manufacturing, the cell where women's ownership was highest in 2015–16, shrank as a share of all enterprises. The fall in contract dependence among women owners is large. It suggests that the subcontracting linkages documented for the earlier rounds (Kesar, 2024) have become less common among women's enterprises, at least in the forms the surveys record.

The results do not support the optimistic reading either. Most of the new women-owned enterprises are home-based units selling on their own account: the rural home-based manufacturing cell alone accounts for 35.8 per cent of the rise, and home-based own-market

cells together for 65.3 per cent, against 43.6 per cent for own-market enterprises outside the home. These are the units with the lowest returns in the data. Their median value added per worker is below what a woman casual worker earns in 25 days, and below the average 30-day earnings that self-employed women report in the PLFS (Rs 5,497). The gap with men persists after controlling for activity, state, location, contract status and time worked, as in earlier work on women-owned firms in India and elsewhere (Bose, 2023; de Mel, McKenzie, and Woodruff, 2009; Fafchamps et al., 2014).

Two readings fit these facts. One is that the enterprise surveys now capture more of the low-intensity, home-based production that women combine with domestic work, which the shorter hours of women's enterprises suggest; in that case the rise in ownership is partly a rise in measured, rather than actual, activity. The other is that more women have taken up independent self-employment because wage work close to home is scarce, so that the enterprise is a fallback rather than an opportunity, in the sense of Shuvam and Mohanty (2023). The data cannot separate these, nor can they tell whether some enterprises are recorded in a woman's name while being run jointly within the household. Both readings imply that the count of women owners is a weak indicator of women's economic progress.

Three caveats apply. First, eight years separate the rounds, and the period includes the 2016 demonetisation, the introduction of the goods and services tax in 2017 and the pandemic; the comparison describes the net change and does not attribute it to any of them. The published one-year rise in the female-proprietor share between ASUSE 2022–23 and 2023–24 (22.9 to 26.2 per cent) also suggests that part of the change is recent. Second, GVA per worker is not the owner's income: it includes the return to capital and is shared with unpaid helpers. Third, the PLFS casual wage is the earning of women who found casual work, and may overstate what the average woman proprietor could earn outside her enterprise.

6 Conclusion

Between 2015–16 and 2023–24 the share of India's unincorporated non-agricultural enterprises with a woman proprietor rose from 19.5 to 26.3 per cent in a common coverage. The

rise was not driven by home-based contract work, which declined, but by home-based enterprises selling on their own account, most of which generate less value added per worker than casual wage work. For research, this means that ownership is a poor proxy for entrepreneurship in these surveys unless it is combined with location, contract status and returns, all of which the surveys already collect. For policy, programmes that set targets in terms of the number of women-owned enterprises would do better to track the share of those enterprises that operate outside the home, sell on their own account and earn more than the local wage.

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Data availability. The unit-level data of the NSS 73rd round, ASUSE 2023–24 and PLFS 2023–24 are available from the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation at microdata.gov.in on registration. The code that produces every number in the paper is available from the author and will be deposited in a public repository on acceptance.

Use of AI tools. Claude (Anthropic) and other AI tools assisted with writing and checking code, checking references and drafting text. The author verified all code, results and references and takes full responsibility for the content.

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Appendix

Table 5: PLFS 2023–24: average daily wage of women casual workers in current weekly status by quarter, estimated from unit data and as published

Quarter	Area	Published	Estimate	Difference
Q1	India	293	293.8	0.8
Q1	Rural	289	289.1	0.1
Q1	Urban	345	350.2	5.2
Q2	India	293	295.1	2.1
Q2	Rural	287	288.8	1.8
Q2	Urban	348	355.5	7.5
Q3	India	293	293.8	0.8
Q3	Rural	286	286.8	0.8
Q3	Urban	358	360.4	2.4
Q4	India	306	307.3	1.3
Q4	Rural	299	299.8	0.8
Q4	Urban	364	368.8	4.8

Table 6: Enterprise surveys: estimates from the unit data against the published figures. ASUSE coverage excludes residential renting (NIC 68108); GVA refers to market enterprises. Sources: ASUSE 2023-24 factsheet; NSS 73rd round key indicators.

Statistic	Estimate	Published	Difference (%)
ASUSE 2023-24: establishments (crore)	7.34	7.34	0.00
ASUSE 2023-24: workers (crore)	12.06	12.06	0.00
ASUSE 2023-24: female proprietary, % of establishments	26.17	26.20	-0.11
ASUSE 2023-24: annual GVA (Rs crore)	1,797,277.55	1,797,278.00	0.00
ASUSE 2023-24: annual GVA per worker (Rs)	149,742.05	149,742.00	0.00
ASUSE 2023-24: annual GVA per establishment (Rs)	245,686.76	245,687.00	0.00
NSS 73: enterprises (crore)	6.34	6.34	-0.01
NSS 73: female proprietary, % of enterprises	19.54	19.50	0.23
NSS 73: female proprietary, % of OAEs	22.31	22.30	0.05
NSS 73: female proprietary, % of establishments	4.82	4.80	0.45
NSS 73: annual GVA (Rs crore)	1,152,338.82	1,152,338.00	0.00
NSS 73: annual GVA per worker (Rs)	103,743.54	103,744.00	0.00
NSS 73: annual GVA per enterprise (Rs)	181,908.06	181,908.00	0.00